

The Industrial Revolution

European architecture in the 19th century was profoundly altered by the Industrial Revolution of c.1760–1840. In earlier times, for instance, multi-storey buildings depended on stout walls and buttresses: the taller the building, the thicker the lower sections had to be. That changed when forged iron and milled steel began to displace wood, brick and stone as primary materials for the infrastructure of tall buildings.

As machinery took over menial tasks, towns expanded as workers moved from farms to factories. Buildings sprang up to meet demand, including town halls, museums, libraries, hospitals, shops, schools, colleges, banks, offices, warehouses and factories. The advent of rail travel – the first passenger railway was opened in England in 1825 – created a need for new structures, such as stations, railway hotels and bridges. Technological progress inspired architects with new ideas, but they also borrowed from diverse historical styles, including Greek, Roman, Islamic, Byzantine, Gothic and Renaissance.



Iron Bridge at Coalbrookdale, England, Thomas Pritchard, 1777–81